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47 KILLED AS A POWERFUL EARTHQUAKE BATTERS COLOMBIA

Residents and rescue workers search through the rubble of a collapsed building after an earthquake struck Cali, Colombia, yesterday. The powerful 7.4-magnitude earthquake rocked Colombia and neighbouring Latin American countries, with at least 47 people confirmed dead in first reports as shocked residents surveyed destroyed buildings. The early-morning quake was also felt in Ecuador, Panama and Venezuela.

SEE ALSO P7

Oman scrambles to contain oil spill

DUBAI

Gulf News Report

Oman yesterday said it was working to contain an oil spill off its southern coast after a tanker ran aground in June inside a protected marine area, triggering calls for action by environmentalists.

The Oman Environment Authority yesterday said the ongoing spill had affected roughly 390 square kilometres, according to its most recent analysis.

The slick was concentrated around Oman's Hal-laniyat archipelago off the country's southern coast, where a marine reserve was established last year to protect sensitive ecosystems home to diverse marine life, including rare sea turtles.

The country's environment authority said rapid action was needed to protect the area's biodiversity, including "coral reefs, turtle nesting areas, marine habitats and coastal areas of ecological importance".

Omani authorities have not yet identified the cause of the spill. But British maritime security company Vanguard told AFP last week that the tanker was rocked by explosions in early June as it sailed off the coast of Yemen, causing water to enter several sections of the vessel.

The ship is believed to be part of Russia's "shadow fleet" that Moscow uses to circumvent Western sanctions on its oil exports.

SEE ALSO P5, 6

Abu Dhabi offers free UAE visas to Indian tourists

NEW PROGRAMME IS SET TO RUN UNTIL OCTOBER 31

DUBAI

BY DHANUSHA GOKULAN
Chief Reporter

Indian tourists can now get their UAE entry visa free when booking a holiday in Abu Dhabi under a new programme launched by the emirate's tourism authority.

The initiative, launched by the Department of Culture and Tourism – Abu Dhabi (DCT Abu Dhabi), applies to eligible Indian passport holders booking an Abu Dhabi holiday through participating travel partners and online travel agencies (OTA).

The programme runs until October 31, and is available for bookings that include a minimum three-night stay in an Abu Dhabi hotel and a return flight from India. The programme will initially support up to 20,000 visas during its pilot period.

DCT Abu Dhabi will cover the full cost of the UAE entry visa for eligible bookings, reducing the upfront cost for Indian travellers visiting the emirate. India remains a key international tourism market for Abu Dhabi, according to DCT Abu Dhabi.

More accessible

Abdulla Yousuf, Director of International Operations at DCT Abu Dhabi, said: "India continues to be one of our most important international markets, and we remain committed to working closely with our travel partners to make Abu Dhabi even more accessible for Indian travellers."

He said covering the visa cost would make it simpler for Indian travellers to choose Abu Dhabi while giving travel partners another reason to rec-



■ Tourists visit the Sheikh Zayed Grand Mosque in Abu Dhabi.

PREREQUISITES

- A minimum three consecutive nights in an Abu Dhabi hotel
- A return flight from India
- Booking through a participating travel partner or online travel agency

20,000

visas to be supported by the programme during its pilot period

ommend the destination. Yousuf added: "We look forward to welcoming more visitors as they spend longer exploring Abu Dhabi's culture, entertainment, hospitality and natural attractions."

The initiative follows recent

efforts by Abu Dhabi to strengthen air connectivity, expand travel trade partnerships and create new opportunities for Indian visitors.

The offer is available to Indian passport holders departing from India who book an Abu Dhabi holiday through a participating travel partner.

No independent application

Travellers cannot apply independently for the offer. The programme has been developed specifically for participating travel partners and OTAs.

Participating travel partners can choose between two options. ■ They can work through a DCT-appointed destination management company (DMC), with DCT Abu Dhabi covering the visa costs directly.

■ Alternatively, travel partners can continue working with their existing DMC partners. In this case, DCT Abu Dhabi will reimburse Dh285 for each visa issued.

UAE hiring recovery ranks among world's strongest

LinkedIn data shows improving recruitment and talent inflows

DUBAI

BY NIVETHA DAYANAND
Assistant Business Editor

The UAE recorded one of the strongest post-pandemic hiring recoveries among major global markets in 2025, with recruitment remaining above pre-2019 levels across several sectors, according to a LinkedIn report released in partnership with the Ministry of Foreign Trade.

The UAE Economic Graph Report 2026 said real estate posted the strongest hiring growth compared with 2019, while education, construction, health care, administrative services and transport and logistics also remained above the national average.

Volatility eases

After volatility in early 2026, LinkedIn data showed hiring activity and inbound talent flows improving by June.

● The UAE also ranked first globally in FinTech skills and second in attracting artificial intelligence talent relative to population size.

Dr Thani Bin Ahmed Al Zeyoudi, UAE Minister of Foreign Trade and Minister in charge of Attracting and Retaining Talent, said: "The results of this report confirm the success of the country's economic policies in building a global business environment that attracts the brightest minds, talents and quality investments, in support of our national goal of building a more competitive and sustainable economy."

The UAE also ranked first globally in FinTech skills and second in attracting artificial intelligence talent relative to population size. Professional services accounted for 14.5 per cent of LinkedIn members in the country, followed by manufacturing at 12 per cent and accommodation and hospitality at 9.2 per cent.

SEE ALSO P-III

Dubai gears up to host Women's T20 Asia Cup

8-team line-up to see game's biggest stars

DUBAI

BY ROBERT ILSLEY
Sports Reporter

Dubai is ready to host a blockbuster tournament again – the sixth edition of the Women's T20 Asia Cup at the Dubai International Cricket Stadium.

Running from August 28 to September 13, Asia's finest cricketing nations will go head-to-head with continental glory up for grabs. The 2026 edition will be the sixth T20-format tournament, taking place in the UAE for the first time.

The eight-team line-up brings together some of the biggest names in women's Asian cricket alongside several emerging sides.

Defending champions Sri Lanka will be looking to retain the trophy after claiming their first Women's T20 Asia Cup title in 2024, while seven-time winners India

remain the most successful team in the competition and will be among the favourites. Pakistan and Bangladesh will also provide strong competition, with both established as regulars at the top level of women's cricket.



The tournament will also give fans the chance to see UAE, Thailand, Malaysia and Nepal take on the continent's leading teams. The UAE will be looking to make the most of home advantage, while Thailand, Malaysia and Nepal continue to build their presence on the international stage.

SEE ALSO P16

IN FOCUS

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BUSINESS

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